

International Public Management Journal

ISSN: 1096-7494 (Print) 1559-3169 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/upmj20

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To cite this article: Darren Hawkins, Celeste Beesley, Daniel Nielson, João V. Guedes-Neto, Aubriana Wolferts & Nicholas Moffitt (20 Jul 2026): Bureaucratic interest in academic evidence: a field experiment in Tanzania, India and Peru, International Public Management Journal, DOI: 10.1080/10967494.2026.2674553

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/10967494.2026.2674553

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Published online: 20 Jul 2026.

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INTERNATIONAL PUBLIC MANAGEMENT JOURNAL
https://doi.org/10.1080/10967494.2026.2674553

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RESEARCH ARTICLE

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Bureaucratic interest in academic evidence: a field experiment in Tanzania, India and Peru

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ABSTRACT

We investigate how different types of messaging by academics impact public servants' behavioral demand for access to academic evidence by inviting nearly 9,000 national-level government bureaucrats in Tanzania, India and Peru to receive training on an original website that summarizes and graphically depicts findings from hundreds of randomized controlled trials. Implementing well-known interventions from the psychology of choice literature, we sought to test whether "nudges" might work across different national and bureaucratic contexts. We tested randomly assigned messaging characteristics related to messenger identity and social proof. In particular, we randomized whether invitations came from U.S. researchers on location or similar local researchers. We find that bureaucrats were significantly more responsive to U.S. researchers in Peru but not in India or Tanzania. We also randomly assigned information that other bureaucrats in the same ministry had previously expressed interest. Contrary to findings from other populations with similar "social proof" treatments, bureaucrats were less interested when informed that others had already accepted the demonstration. This novel finding is likely due to the institutional context of bureaucracies, where knowledge is more likely to be either a shared resource or a competitive advantage. In this context, others' access to knowledge disincentivizes individual action rather than communicating a norm. This study offers evidence about some possible approaches and pitfalls to effective dissemination of academic evidence.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 17 March 2025
Accepted 8 May 2026

Politicians and bureaucrats in international organizations and in both developed and developing countries have increasingly advocated for "evidence-based" policymaking (Head 2010; Nutley, Walter, and Davies 2007), yet numerous studies suggest that evidence is still under-utilized (Newman, Cherney, and Head 2017)—a longstanding issue (Caplan 1979) that is more pronounced in lower-income countries (Young 2005). Academics often produce policy evidence that could be relevant to public servants, and many research organizations have programs to promote that evidence in policy arenas. Still, little is known about how to bridge the gap between academic supply and bureaucratic demand for evidence. In this paper, we address the challenge of how to more effectively disseminate impact evidence to bureaucrats by focusing on how academics communicate with bureaucrats.[1] We conducted a field experiment with 8,910 bureaucrats from three developing countries across Asia, Africa, and Latin America, where obstacles to accessing scientific evidence are more prevalent (Ho and Im 2015; Mani 2021).[2]

While supply of academic evidence is limited, many development-oriented research organizations have been working to produce more policy-relevant research. The field of development economics has been substantially impacted by the introduction of randomized control trials

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Supplemental data for this article can be accessed online at https://doi.org/10.1080/10967494.2026.2674553.
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(RCTs) as a tool of choice to inform decision-making in several policy sectors, for example, poverty alleviation (Banerjee and Duflo 2009; Banerjee, Duflo, and Kremer 2016; Rodgers et al. 2020; Krause and Hernández Licona 2020). Beyond academia, major development agencies provide funding and incentives to conduct and use such evaluations.[3] Impact evidence—in which policy programs are evaluated for causal effects on pre-determined outcomes using randomized control trials—are often considered an especially important type of evidence.[4] Despite the increasing abundance of policy-relevant academic evidence, several studies show that evidence use in policy making is relatively sparse, with one noting that bureaucrats make use of evidence "only in exceptional circumstances" (Head 2015).

A necessary pre-condition for using academic evidence in government bureaucracies is individual-level demand for such evidence. Many governments have taken important steps to promote evidence use in their policy processes, such as creating monitoring and evaluation units to supply and promote evidence use. Nevertheless, gaps remain between evidence and policy in each of the countries included in this study (see, for example, Kattumuri 2015; Dasgupta 2017 for India; Boyco 2015; López-Rodríguez et al. 2017; OECD 2016 for Peru: Goodluck 2021; Mori et al. 2014; Erismann et al. 2021 for Tanzania). Those gaps are especially likely to be pronounced between academic evidence and public-servant interest, in part because academics often write up their results with other audiences in mind. Gaps also exist because internal bureaucratic mechanisms to promote individual-level interest in evidence are imperfect. Individual public servants face many competing demands for their time and attention. Academic evidence can easily take a back seat to other more pressing concerns.

To be sure, we are not suggesting that academic studies centered on RCTs are a panacea. The implementation of those studies is oftentimes imperfect and biased (Ravallion 2020; Shaffer 2011) and may produce incomplete information for scaling up policy interventions (Davis and Mobarak 2020). Furthermore, scientific evidence is only part of the story when it comes to sound policymaking. Drèze (2020) argues that good policy also requires understanding deriving from, for instance, personal experience; values, which consider the policy actors' viewpoints and objectives; and deliberations, or political decisions based on democratic processes.

However, academic impact evidence studies still provide some relevant information that, combined with other elements, should contribute to better policies. To probe how to improve communications that might increase demand, we created a website targeted to policymakers featuring summaries of academic impact-evidence studies. The website aims to lower supply-side costs by facilitating access to research results (using standardized and graphical summaries) and studies (providing links to academic papers), providing a normatively desirable mix of accessibility and sophistication (Court and Maxwell 2005). Aware that low policy capacity may be a barrier to accessing and absorbing this type of knowledge (see Howlett 2009:2015; Howlett and Newman 2010), we offered in-person demonstrations to 8,910 non-elected national-level bureaucrats in Tanzania, India, and Peru in 2017. The website at that time presented findings from over 400 RCT-based policy evaluation studies sourced from academic and policy institutions, such as J-PAL, IPA, and CEGA.[5] By offering a relatively low-cost supply of impact evidence, we overcome many use obstacles—such as language, financial, and networking barriers—and can isolate the effects of messaging on demand. We measure demand for impact evidence not simply through expressions of interest in the website, but through the acceptance and completion of training sessions to use the website.

We use the process of contacting bureaucrats to test how different messaging and messengers might influence bureaucrats' demand for impact evidence. In doing so, we deployed experimental methods to causally test theoretical ideas that are widespread in psychology and political science literatures to encourage respondents using the "psychology of choice" (Tversky and Kahneman 1981:453; Thaler and Sunstein 2008). In doing so, we tested the assumption that bureaucrats behave as "people in general" (Tullock, Brady, and Seldon 2002:53), that is, the choice literature tested here hypothesizes no particular limitations to psychological effects based on job type, training, or other contexts discussed here. Our findings, as we will demonstrate, partially

challenge this notion, showing that, for instance, an implementation of social proof does not increase public employees' interest in pursuing impact evidence.

This experiment represents a significant and extensive real-world effort to bridge the gap between academics and policymakers. Furthermore, it does so while answering recent calls for more studies about policy processes in developing economies (Bertelli et al. 2020; Shamsul Haque, van der Wal, and van den Berg 2021; Ames, Carreras, and Schwartz 2012). Despite substantive interest in evidence-based policy in development economics, most literature on bureaucratic behavior is still concentrated in the developed world. Cantarelli, Belle, and Hall (2023) looked at the top 14 public administration journals to find 162 papers investigating the use of information in public decisions. Out of those, only 13 focused on either Asia (11), Africa (1), or South America (1). We, therefore, can provide insights on the implementation of evidence-based policymaking where it is most needed but least studied.

We conducted our study across three continents to capture the diversity within developing countries. Instead of exploring contextual differences between countries, we focused on whether widely theorized universal interventions would produce similar results across different bureaucratic contexts. Our investigation targeted the motivations of public personnel in developing countries to access academic information. A survey of roughly 12,000 Latin American bureaucrats (authors' unpublished research) found that 89% wanted better access to high-quality academic evidence, and 61% believed evidence is underused in policy decisions. We tested whether these attitudinal measures translate into behavioral demand demonstrated by costly actions, such as attending training prompted by an unsolicited email invitation or phone call.

We explored two distinct randomized treatments in our invitations to bureaucrats. The first focused on messenger characteristics. Messenger characteristics or "source cues" often drive audience interest and message influence (Druckman 2001; Druckman et al. 2010). For the *country-of-origin conditions*, researchers with similar characteristics (university undergraduate and master's students) from different nationalities (U.S. nationals and locals) were randomly assigned to contact each bureaucrat in each of the three countries. Second, half of our invitations included information that peers had already accepted the invitation—the *social proof conditions* (see Cialdini, Reno, and Kallgren 1990; Nolan et al. 2008; Schultz, Khazian, and Zaleski 2008).

As measures of bureaucrats' demonstrated demand for impact evidence, we examine three different outcomes: 1) positive responses to the invitation; 2) whether bureaucrats actually met with researchers; and 3) the number of bureaucrats that the initial subjects recruited for the demonstrations. Around nine percent of the sample responded positively to our invitation. This is higher than most elite response rates in survey and field experiments (Nielson, Hyde, and Kelley 2019).

We find that U.S. messengers received similar responses to their invitations in our pooled sample when compared to local researchers, but bureaucrats did invite more people to trainings with US messengers. The pooled results mask substantial cross-national variation. Peruvian bureaucrats consistently were more likely to respond to invitations from U.S. messengers and Peruvian and Tanzanian bureaucrats recruited more people to attend meetings with those messengers.

Contrary to expectation and previous findings on social proof, in the pooled sample bureaucrats prompted that ministry peers had previously accepted invitations for briefings were *less* likely to accept invitations than in the control condition. Again, substantial cross-national variation exists, with null results in Peru and generally negative results in India and Tanzania. Both treatments suggest that the effects of messaging are significantly conditioned by national context, thereby creating more opportunities for a learning dialogue between the literatures on public administration, development economics, and the psychology of choice.

This study makes three contributions to research on evidence use in public administration. First, we advance behavioral perspectives on bureaucratic decision-making by identifying how messenger credibility and descriptive peer information shape bureaucrats' behavioral demand for academic evidence, even when informational access barriers are minimized. Second, we provide

one of the first large-scale field experiments to measure costly, real-world engagement with impact evidence among national-level bureaucrats across three developing-country contexts, moving beyond self-reported interest and hypothetical willingness to use evidence. Third, we show that a widely successful behavioral intervention—social proof—likely communicates a different message when embedded in an institutionalized bureaucratic context than in the general public, leading to lower, rather than higher, engagement in the prompted behavior. Together, these contributions enhance understanding of how psychological and organizational factors interact to shape the conditions under which academic evidence becomes salient and actionable for public servants.

Theory and hypotheses

Previous studies have documented the serious hurdles that exist in increasing demand for impact evidence (Head 2015; Newman, Cherney, and Head 2017; Grindle and Thomas 1989). Public servants of course must juggle many imposed priorities, including bureaucratic guidelines, the preferences of superiors, and the views of social stakeholders or third-party funders (Head 2010; Weiss 1999), which can limit their interest in impact evidence. Bureaucrats also have their own internal biases, training, experiences, psychological profiles, and political dispositions (Butler et al. 2017; Banuri, Dercon, and Gauri 2019) that affect demand for such evidence.

While elected officials formally initiate or authorize many policies, a substantial body of research shows that bureaucrats play a central role in shaping what policies become in practice. Bureaucrats help define policy problems, provide technical alternatives, and translate broad legislative directives into operational rules and resource decisions (Pressman and Wildavsky 1973; Page and Jenkins 2005; Blom-Hansen, Baekgaard, and Serritzlew 2021). This policymaking influence is not restricted to frontline implementation; mid-level and managerial bureaucrats often exercise discretion over program design, standard-setting, and coordination (Evans and Hupe 2020; Peters and Pierre 2023). Accordingly, bureaucratic demand for academic evidence is directly relevant for how policy is interpreted, adapted, and delivered. Our study focuses on these bureaucrats precisely because their decisions shape the knowledge base on which government action is grounded.

Effective messaging may help mitigate some of the difficulties in connecting bureaucrats to impact evidence. Substantial research in the psychology-of-choice tradition suggests that source cues are essential to the success of political messages (Druckman 2001; Druckman et al. 2010). Before investigating new information, potential users take cues about its quality or applicability based on the source. Such cues may concern credibility, ideology, values, usefulness, or other factors. In fact, whether individuals accept a particular message may have more to do with external cues than with the content of the message itself (Butler et al. 2017).

Scholars have identified credibility as perhaps the most important signal in the process of communicating persuasive messages (Miller and Krosnick 2000; Druckman 2001; Pornpitakpan 2004). Messages originating from countries that have achieved higher levels of development may be perceived as more credible. This may be especially true for scientific information, where some countries (including the United States) have notably strong reputations. Therefore, bureaucrats may see messages about academic evidence as more credible if they are associated with locations with strong reputations for both higher education and policy effectiveness.

More broadly, one could conceptualize bureaucrats as information consumers. The reputation of the home country has been shown to influence consumer choice and even outweigh the price or the advertised quality of the product (Okechuku 1994). In a review of the literature, Papadopoulos and Heslop (2002:298) found that country of origin provides a "powerful stereotype" that influences many consumers. Country brand indices routinely place the U.S. "brand" higher than those of developing countries, including the research sites in this study.[6] Where bureaucrats know very little about the substantive content of information, country-of-origin

effects may be powerful. U.S. messenger nationality potentially offers cues that the information on the website was compiled or selected by reputable gatekeepers.

On the other hand, and pointing in the opposite causal direction, the presentation of evidence by a compatriot might provide a stronger signal that the resource is relevant to the problems that developing-country bureaucrats face. In the political arena, studies have typically found that foreign messengers have "little effect … or trigger a backlash against their championed policy" (Dragojlovic 2015:73). Additionally, those from other countries may face a "liability of foreignness" (Zaheer 1995) due to foreigners' unfamiliarity with local culture, practices, and accepted behavior. In government, the liability of foreignness also appears as the rejection of foreign ideologies or the ideology stereotypically linked to a certain country (Morgenstern and Bohigues 2021).

The messenger treatment reflects two theoretically grounded but competing mechanisms: local messengers may be perceived as more contextually legitimate and politically attuned, while U.S.-based academic messengers may be perceived as more technically authoritative. Given these countervailing expectations in the literature, we specify competing hypotheses and empirically adjudicate between them.

Hypothesis 1a: Bureaucrats in developing countries should be more responsive to invitations from U.S. messengers when compared with local messengers.

Hypothesis 1b: Bureaucrats in developing countries should be more responsive to invitations from local messengers when compared with U.S. messengers.

In addition to messenger nationality, researchers in the psychology of choice tradition have repeatedly demonstrated that people generally conform to behaviors they understand to be typical, a concept known as social proof (Cialdini, Reno, and Kallgren 1990). In experiments, social proof treatments are simply messages stating that peers act in particular way. Those peers need not be known to the person receiving the message. For example, messages that others paid their taxes increased payment rates for overdue taxes (Hallsworth et al. 2017).

Peer observation has also been shown to influence bureaucratic behavior. Civil servants learn appropriate behavior from observing their colleagues (March 1992; March and Olsen 1996). This mechanism, namely "the logic of appropriateness," is especially relevant for motivating those with functional preferences to act in favor of strengthening their agencies (Brehm and Gates 1999) and, overall, the public sector (Perry 1997). Intra-government social proof should thus play a role in motivating bureaucrats to seek out academic evidence. Following the logic of appropriateness rationale (March and Olsen 1996), bureaucrats may perceive evidence-based policy to be desirable if their colleagues demonstrate interest in learning about it. This will likely motivate them to respond positively when given the opportunity. We thus hypothesize that:

Hypothesis 2: Messages employing social proof should prompt more responsiveness from bureaucrats when compared with a control condition.

Experimental context

Despite avowed policymaker interest,[7] research is split on whether academic evidence has influence on government bureaucrats (Newman, Cherney, and Head 2017; Cairney, Oliver, and Wellstead 2016; Head 2015, 2016; Hjort et al. 2021; Vivalt and Coville 2023). In their survey with Australian bureaucrats, Newman, Cherney, and Head (2016:25) found that "a substantial number of survey respondents (…) do not value academic research very highly and do not often use the findings of academic research when constructing advice for making policy." Hjort et al. (2021), however, find that policymakers update their beliefs in response to evidence, but do so in selective ways.

This is perhaps unsurprising since such studies are not presented in ways that bureaucrats find easy to understand and digest. Academic studies are typically written for academic

audiences, using arcane language and methods, inscrutable mathematical models, and insider jargon. Understanding and comparing academic studies requires time, effort, experience, and sophistication—often even for those with appropriate training (Newman, Cherney, and Head 2016, 2017; Howlett 2009, 2015; Howlett and Newman 2010; Koga et al. 2022). Moreover, the studies are generally written in English, a language over which many government employees in developing countries do not have a deep mastery. These factors can raise the cost of using impact evidence to a level where bureaucratic demand is so low that it is difficult to study.

Because prior studies have pointed to the importance of knowledge-brokering to potentially overcome these barriers (Cairney, Oliver, and Wellstead 2016; Davies, Nutley, and Walter 2007) and following a growing number of field experiments in public bureaucracies (Hansen and Tummers 2020), we designed an experiment to use in-person contact to provide introduction and training for a website designed to make findings from academic research accessible. We, thus, attempt to mitigate the challenge of political analytical capacity (see Howlett 2009:2015; Howlett and Newman 2010) before assessing the factors that motivate information-seeking behavior.

Prior to the experiment, we created a free, easy-to-use website that summarizes key findings of policy-relevant academic studies that utilize impact evidence. The website presents them in an accessible graphical format as well as provides links to the full study. While some scholarly organizations have increasingly engaged in policy outreach, most efforts do not present graphical results or translations of academic findings into local languages. J-PAL, one of the most prominent development-policy academic centers in the world, typically offers lengthy summaries that rely solely on English-language text.[8] The World Bank sometimes offers English-language blog posts summarizing research, but those posts tend to consist of many text paragraphs with minimal graphs and very little by way of policy orientation.[9]

Our website summarized the key findings of more than 400 RCTs produced by some of the most well-known development-oriented research networks in the United States. While RCTs are not the only form of academic evidence, they suit our purposes because they have a reputation for rigor and the results can be presented with minimum ambiguity and maximum interpretability, especially in a policy context (Banerjee and Duflo 2009; Banerjee, Duflo, and Kremer 2016; Rodgers et al. 2020). The website uses easy-to-understand graphs and favors those graphs over words in presenting the main results from each study. To facilitate access further, we also provide a translation of our website in Spanish. Screen shots of the website home page and a randomly selected project page are shown in the Supplementary Information, Figures A1 and A2. The website contains information from impact evaluations across the world in different fields including education, health, agriculture, finance, governance, and business. Bureaucrats across sectors ought to be able to find studies on topics of interest to them. Since bureaucrats regularly encounter various kinds of information and individuals wanting to meet with them, we believe that our invitation and meeting request was not atypical.

We selected Peru, Tanzania, and India as sites for our study to provide diversity among world regions and levels of development while maintaining an ability to approach bureaucrats in a language accessible to our researchers (English in India and Tanzania; Spanish in Peru). While one cannot generalize from single cases or our group of three cases, it is helpful to know some context about those cases when understanding research design and interpreting results. The study follows others in assessing treatment heterogeneity of unified experimental conditions across multiple country contexts (Banerjee et al. 2015; Blair et al. 2021; Slough et al. 2021). We sought diverse cases that were not outliers on fundamental country-level characteristics such as democracy levels, GDP per capita, and security issues. Details may be found in the Supporting Information, Note A2. We expect that different case selection may have produced somewhat different results but that we can also learn something from the cases we chose.

Unfortunately, scholars lack good country-level measures of the interest in academic impact evidence, so we can say little about the nature of the preexisting demand. Our review of the

policy literature in all three countries identified many assessments of substantial gaps between policy and evidence (Boyco 2015; Dasgupta 2017; Erismann et al. 2021; Goodluck 2021; Kattumuri 2015; López-Rodríguez et al. 2017; Mori et al. 2014; OECD 2016). In the absence of systematic country comparisons on evidence demand, we did not have specific expectations about how messenger nationality and social proof treatments would differ across countries but were interested in exploring variation. This is a comparatively rare approach in experiments in developing countries, which typically focus on a single country. Our results suggest meaningful differences across the countries, which we discuss below.

Research design

For this study, the relevant universe consists of unelected national government officials (bureaucrats) in each country's capital city whose names and contact information were readily available on national-level government websites. As comprehensive rosters of bureaucrats were unavailable, prior to fieldwork we scraped the websites of national government ministries, sub-ministries, and related agencies to create a sampling frame.[10] We included all listed contacts excluding only elected officials since electoral considerations would likely influence interests and incentives. Sampling across all ministries allows us to examine evidence uptake under realistic institutional variation in professional norms, rather than only in agencies predisposed to value external research. Because treatment was randomized within ministries, and ministry-level effects are modeled explicitly in our analyses, differences in sectoral-evidence culture do not bias the estimated treatment effects. The official websites used identify current position-holders, but they do not systematically include information on hiring mode (e.g., merit-based civil-service recruitment vs. provisional or political appointment). Because these classifications vary across agencies and are not consistently recorded in publicly accessible formats, it was not feasible to obtain this information for the sample. However, any systematic differences in bureaucrats by hiring type should, in expectation, be balanced across randomized experimental conditions and thus should pose no threat to causal inference.

Teams of five to eight research associates from the United States traveled to Peru, India, and Tanzania in July and August of 2017. While the COVID-19 pandemic has since reshaped aspects of public administration, the mechanisms we study—how bureaucrats respond to messenger credibility and descriptive social proof—stem from longstanding psychological processes that have demonstrated stability across contexts and time. Our treatments do not depend on the specific policy climate of 2017, but on generalizable dynamics of trust, legitimacy, and organizational behavior. Our findings therefore contribute not to a specific policy moment, but to the broader understanding of evidence uptake in developing-country bureaucracies.

The researchers included both undergraduate and master's degree university students. In Peru, all U.S. researchers had high-level conversational abilities in Spanish derived from at least 18 months of residence in a Spanish-speaking locale. To randomize researcher nationality, in each location we hired equal numbers of local researchers with similar academic qualifications. To accomplish independent experimental manipulation of nationality (U.S. or local treatments) and social proof (treatment or control), we assigned each factorial treatment independently using computerized random assignment. We block randomized to minimize collinearity of treatment assignment with country and ministry. This process randomly assigned an equivalent number of bureaucrats within each country ministry to each of the four conditions. See Supplementary Information, Tables A1 and A2 for the distribution of bureaucrats by treatment condition or by ministry. Table A3 shows the response rates by ministry. Tables A4 and A5 show the balance tests between each treatment and subject ministry and the few other control variables available for all subjects. Randomization was conducted independently within each country using block random assignment by ministry. As might be expected under this procedure in a field experiment, the realized treatment–control proportions vary somewhat. While some differences appear (across countries, in female enumerators, and whether subjects were emailed), they remain

consistent with random assignment. All main analyses include adjustment in estimation for all measured covariates, which improves statistical precision under unequal cell sizes without altering the unbiasedness of the treatment-effect estimator.

All reachable subjects received emails or phone calls containing treatment language, so there was no pure control condition to be contaminated by spillovers. We could not track potential spillovers such as email forwarding or conversations among subjects, but if such communication occurred, it would be expected to be balanced across experimental conditions. While spillovers may impact the social proof treatment more than the messenger treatment, any differential effects are the result of mechanisms that exist outside of the experiment as a result of the realistic nature of the experiment. Nevertheless, because bureaucratic work is collaborative, participants may indeed share training information with colleagues, creating spillovers. To the extent these occurred, they would likely attenuate—rather than inflate—estimated treatment effects by diffusing access to the opportunity across conditions. The findings below may therefore represent conservative estimates of the effect of messenger nationality and social proof on bureaucratic demand for evidence.

Researchers initially contacted bureaucrats by email in all three countries. Where bureaucrats were non-responsive, we followed up with telephone calls.[11] Researchers provided bureaucrats with a brief description of the website and an invitation to schedule an in-person meeting (at the official's convenience) to demonstrate and provide access to the website. Researchers specified that they worked for our research organization (Impact Evidence) and used Gmail accounts containing their personal names in the address. If the official did not respond to the initial contact, the researcher attempted to re-contact them up to three times *via* email and/or phone calls (all containing the same treatments).[12] There was no mention of compensation for the bureaucrats in any communication. We invited them to receive training individually and indicated they could invite others. Accepting the invitation and including others was entirely at their discretion.

In contacts, researchers explicitly specified their origin (the United States or the local city) and provided their full names, which cued the recipient to the researchers' nationality. In the social proof condition, the contact script informed bureaucrats that colleagues in their ministry had already indicated interest in scheduling a meeting, if that were true. Where it was not true—early in the process before other bureaucrats had indicated an interest—researchers stated that other bureaucrats (without naming a ministry) had responded positively. These claims involved no deception because some bureaucrats in the control group were contacted first and some responded positively. The first round in the treatment group was contacted one or two days later. Follow-up emails followed a rolling design. The social-proof treatment condition also referenced findings that government officials have a strong interest in impact evidence.

In the control condition, researchers emphasized that policy impact evaluations could be helpful but did not mention other bureaucrats. The first paragraph in both the social-proof condition and the control introduced the idea that the website could be helpful. The control condition contained an additional three sentences on this point to ensure that the emails' lengths were similar across conditions. This is a strong control condition, not simply the absence of additional language or a placebo condition with irrelevant information. The wording of the control script is consistent with previous studies on social proof (Nolan et al. 2008).

We measure three outcomes that indicate increasing levels of bureaucratic interest in academic evidence. The first is bureaucrats' responses to our contacting them. These are coded as positive if they indicated an interest in continuing a conversation about the project. Because different modes of communication worked better in different countries, national variation arose at this stage. In Peru, 92% of contacts were made by email. In India, 82% were emailed, while in Tanzania only 5% were emailed.[13] Telephone contacting likely affects the nationality treatment. Bureaucrats receiving telephone calls would have been able to immediately identify the caller's nationality by accent. In India and Tanzania, researchers began all conversations in English (an official language in both countries) regardless of researcher nationality, but many bureaucrats

preferred to speak a local language. Local researchers thus frequently switched to local languages while U.S. researchers had limited ability to do so.

In practice, the messenger nationality treatment thus became associated with language. This could be seen as confounding or reinforcing the treatment. Because language and nationality are so highly correlated, it is reasonable to conceptualize the language issue as reinforcing the nationality treatment. It did so in a particularly powerful way by structuring possibilities of communication, part of the "liability of foreignness." To understand how language affected the nationality treatment, it is helpful to compare results from Peru, where all U.S. researchers were able to speak Spanish at a reasonably high level, albeit with an accent. Obviously, U.S. researchers inevitably betrayed some lack of native language ability as they interacted with local bureaucrats beyond the first email (which contained the same script for all researchers). This could have reinforced the nationality treatment, but to a far smaller extent than not being able to speak the local language at all (as in India and Tanzania). The main analyses presented below control for method of contact (email or telephone) to adjust estimated treatment effects for these differences.

Following an indication of interest from a bureaucrat, we scheduled an in-person demonstration of the website. Whether such a training was ultimately held constitutes our second outcome measure. The third measure is a count of how many people were present since respondents were welcomed to invite others at their discretion. Inviting additional attendees indicates higher interest that is plausibly related to the treatments. Unlike survey responses, in which it is costless to indicate interest in academic evidence, answering an email or engaging in a telephone conversation, participating in a training or inviting colleagues costs respondents time and attention. Each level of engagement represents increasingly costly engagement with investigating a resource for greater access to evidence. In all cases, the same researcher was responsible contacting the official and scheduling and conducting the demonstration. See Note A1 in the Supplementary Information for more details.

Results and discussion

We first report results for messenger nationality and social proof treatments for each outcome (positive response, meeting held, number attending) considered separately before conducting robustness checks that account for the sequential nature of the behavioral outcomes. We present estimates of the treatment effects from the pooled three-country sample and for each country individually. Estimates for all three outcomes are based on linear probability models with controls for messenger gender and method of contact as well as messenger random effects and country fixed effects. We prefer linear probability models due to ease of computation and interpretation of results.[14] The random effects account for clustering of standard errors by messenger and are uncorrelated with our randomized treatments. The analyses report coefficients for both randomly assigned treatments conditional on the distribution of the other treatment, omitting interaction terms for treatment combinations. The treatment coefficients are best interpreted as a "composite treatment effect that includes a weighted average of the interactions with other treatments" (Muralidharan, Romero, and Wuthrich 2019:2).

Figure 1 presents the marginal effects of the treatments for each outcome for the pooled sample. The marginal effects are calculated at the mean of all other variables. Figure 1 shows the magnitude and significance of the difference in linear predictions of treatment groups relative to the control group, subject to country controls and messenger random effects. Figure 2 presents the results of the same models for each country individually.

Messenger nationality

In the pooled sample, messenger nationality is insignificantly correlated with positive response and meetings held but does significantly increase the number of people trained. The effect on training is a substantively significant increase of 0.055 from a baseline control group prediction of only 0.041. When assessing results by country, U.S. researchers received more positive responses,

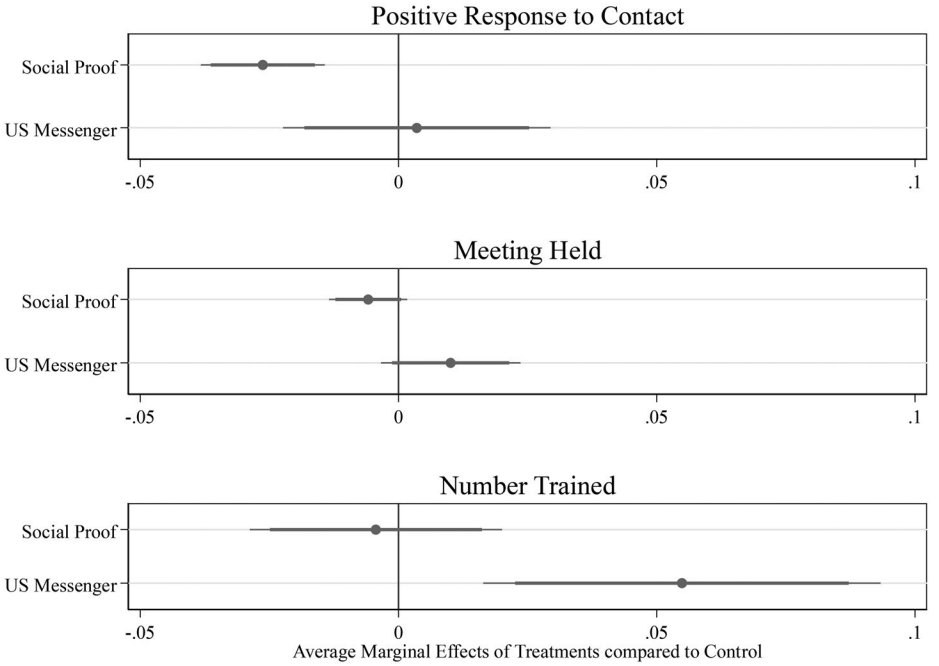


Figure 1. Marginal effects of experimental treatments, pooled sample.
Note: Figure 1 plots the estimated marginal effects of the two experimental conditions from linear probability models (including controls for country, messenger gender and method of contact as well as random effects for messenger). 95 percent confidence intervals are represented by thicker lines. Thinner lines represent 90 percent confidence intervals. Full results reported in Supplementary Information, Table A6. Pooled N: 8787.

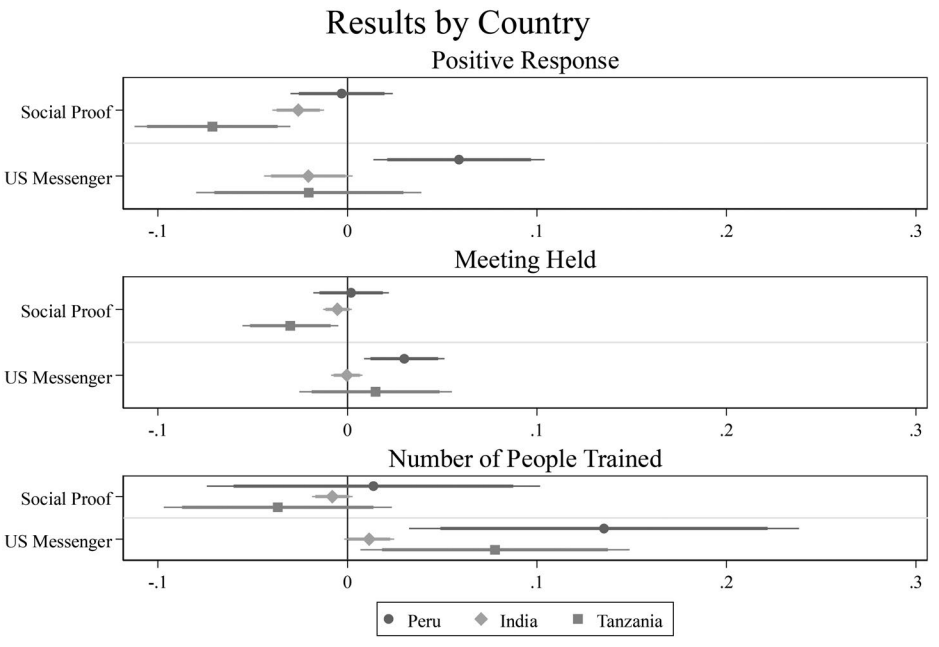


Figure 2. Coefficient plots across outcomes for experimental conditions, by country.
Note: Figure 2 plots the estimated marginal effects of the experimental conditions from linear probability analyses (including controls for messenger gender and method of contact, as well as random effects for messenger) for each country separately. 95 percent confidence intervals are represented by thicker lines. Thinner lines represent 90 percent confidence intervals. Full results reported in Supplementary Information, Table A7. N (Peru): 2230; N (India): 5638; N (Tanzania): 919.

held more meetings, and trained more people in Peru when compared with local researchers. U.S. messengers increased positive responses by roughly 6 percentage points from a base rate of less than ten percent, which suggests appreciable substantive significance. Other effects from the nationality treatment were not significant. One clear takeaway is that national context matters, as prior public administration approaches suspect (Ho and Im 2015; Bertelli et al. 2020; Shamsul Haque, van der Wal, and van den Berg 2021). One possible reason may be different degrees of liability of foreignness based on, for instance, cultural and political distance that impact how much a messenger from the US is seen presenting credible and relevant information relative to a local messenger (Zhou and Guillen 2016).

To ensure our results are not driven by bureaucrats with fewer decision-making responsibilities, in Peru and Tanzania we also present the results for only the subset of those coded as managers based on their job titles (such categorization was not possible in India due to less informative job titles). The results are substantially similar, though the effect of the US Messenger treatment in Peru and Tanzania is driven by managers. Managers are more likely to respond or arrange meetings (in Peru) and have others present at the meetings (in both countries) when they receive the US Messenger treatment, but the treatment does not significantly impact bureaucrats in less clearly managerial roles (see Supplementary Information, Tables A8–A12). This is consistent with our hypotheses and provides greater insight into the process of dissemination of academic evidence.

The evidence generally supports Hypothesis 1a about the attraction of U.S. messengers but not Hypothesis 1b about local messengers. In no country did local researchers perform significantly better than U.S. researchers on any measure. This is true despite the limitations that language imposed on U.S. researchers in India and Tanzania. U.S. researchers trained more people in the overall sample and in Peru and Tanzania individually. They also had far more initial positive responses and meetings held in Peru, where U.S. researchers' fluency in Spanish made language less of an issue. Communicating about sophisticated topics in a language one does not speak well is a daunting process whose costs could undermine the possible credibility advantage. The positive effects of U.S. researchers on the number of people trained in Peru and Tanzania (with positive but insignificant effects in India) could indicate that, once an official decided the language costs were manageable by holding a meeting, others were drawn to attend the meeting with foreigners.

Social proof

Turning to the results of the social proof treatment, in contrast to previous studies, we found negative or null results from priming peer engagement. Prior research has shown social proof effectively increases common behavior (Schultz, Khazian, and Zaleski 2008). However, in our pooled sample at the first stage, social proof significantly decreased positive responses by 2.6 percentage points from a base rate of roughly 10%, a substantively significant reduction in probability by about one-fourth. Social proof also had a meaningfully negative effect on the probability of positively responding in India and Tanzania and, in Tanzania, on the likelihood of holding a meeting. Overall, social proof had consistently negative effects on all three outcomes.

As above, to ensure our results are not driven by bureaucrats without decision-making responsibilities, we consider the subset of those coded as managers based on their job titles in Peru and Tanzania. In Peru, the treatment remains insignificant regardless of position. In Tanzania, the social proof treatment significantly decreases the likelihood of all three outcomes for non-managers, but is insignificant for managers (see Supplementary Information, Tables A8–A12). This indicates that part of the counter-intuitive findings on social proof may be driven by lower-level bureaucrats.[15]

Our treatments were similar to other social-proof treatments in the literature and designed using effective social-proof signals as models, but our results are statistically significant in the opposite direction from prior findings. What, then, might account for our findings that social-proof

treatments were ineffective or counterproductive? One explanation is that the bureaucrats' context differs tremendously from the general public. Previous studies indicate that elites are less likely to listen to the advice of others and more likely to make decisions alone than the average individual (Galinsky et al. 2008; See et al. 2011). This could potentially explain the apparent resistance to social proof. Rather than being motivated by the decisions of others, elites form their own opinions and judgments.

Another possibility is that incentives in the bureaucracy—a hierarchy with defined job roles—caused bureaucrats to react differently. Information in a bureaucratic context may be either a shared, common good or seen as a source of competitive advantage. In either case, the institutional structure would make a social proof prompt a negative incentive, rather than implying a norm with which individuals should comply. If information is a shared good, a social proof prompt may induce a reasonable belief that because others have acted, it is less important to spend time undertaking the training. As we have previously argued, bureaucracies in developing countries are more likely to struggle with low policy capacity, as well as more limited resources than similar agencies in the developed world. These limitations impose more restraints on bureaucrats' ability to dedicate time and effort to non-essential tasks. If they believe that others have already accomplished a given task, they may be prompted to avoid duplication. The findings are consistent with the idea that bureaucrats may infer that, if peers have already accessed the evidence, the information can be obtained indirectly without incurring the personal time cost of attending. Alternatively, if information is used as a competitive advantage, rather than a shared good, the social proof prompts may suggest to bureaucrats that acquiring the evidence is less valuable for them because any personal advantage from it will have been diluted. Thus, the negative response to social proof may reflect strategic allocation of limited attention (whether considering information on the impact evidence as an individual advantage or a collective good) rather than lack of interest in evidence per se. Rather than shirking (see Brehm and Gates 1999), this might indicate optimizing scarce resources. This would be consistent with the stronger and more persistent negative effect of the social-proof treatment among non-managers in Tanzania (see Supplementary Information, Table A6).

To test the robustness of these outcomes using a different approach, we consider the sequential nature of our three outcome variables by flattening the outcomes into sequenced categorical measures (Findley, Nielson, and Sharman 2015; Slough 2023).[16] In the Supplementary Information Tables A41–A44, we present the marginal effects of each treatment (relative to the control or co-national researcher) on the probability of observing these outcomes following multinomial logit analysis. The results are largely consistent with those reported in Figures 1 and 2. Additional robustness checks may be found in the Supplementary Information, as summarized by Note A3. These include models accounting for clustered standard errors, paired bootstrapping, and ministry random effects.

One prominent feature of our findings is the variation by country. This is most pronounced with the messenger treatment but is also present in the social-proof treatment. Challenges by U.S. researchers in communicating in English with subjects were probably most impactful in the early stages of contacting bureaucrats in India and Tanzania. Once bureaucrats had indicated their willingness to press forward despite the language issue, the nature of the treatments became more comparable between the three countries. Our results support the idea that U.S. messengers seem to confer added desirability to a meeting to discuss the website resource offered, rather than a liability of foreignness. National "brand" may, thus, influence beliefs about the quality, credibility, or novelty of the offered academic evidence in some settings, whereas in others this benefit may be offset by concerns about relevance. We, therefore, show that the information messenger is not perceived as value-neutral—a finding that corroborates the proposition that information seekers are biased when seeking evidence (see Parkhurst 2017).

Social proof never produced a positive result for these outcomes, but it was signed positively in Peru and negatively in Tanzania and India. It seems very likely that bureaucratic practices and norms also vary by national context. Indian bureaucrats were generally more resistant to

meetings without the approval of higher-level officials. If they were told that others had already been trained, it would have been a reasonable assumption that the information was thus already processed appropriately in the bureaucratic hierarchy and there was less need for them to proactively schedule a training or to reach out to others to encourage attendance if a meeting was offered. It is plausible that these and related sorts of bureaucratic processes and cultures could account for observed variation in national outcomes.

Conclusion

What kinds of messaging from academics increase public servants' demand for academic evidence in developing countries? We tested two interventions rooted in extensive literature from psychology and political science: messenger identity and social proof. Our findings reveal that results vary by country, indicating that public institutions and other contextual factors can amplify, diminish, or even reverse the effectiveness of interventions that have succeeded in other contexts.

While previous research shows that bureaucrats say they are eager to seek evidence for policymaking, the actual use of scientific evidence remains uncommon (Newman, Cherney, and Head 2017). The public administration literature points to various institutional and contextual factors that conditionally influence evidence uptake (Head 2010:2015; Butler et al. 2017; Banuri, Dercon, and Gauri 2019). Intra-country variation can stem from the content of policy advice (Goyal and Saguin 2019) and the characteristics of public bureaucracies (Koga et al. 2022), while cross-national variation reflects, among others, challenges like policy capacity (Young 2005; Ho and Im 2015; Mani 2021).

While these factors are difficult and slow to change (and, for the most part, outside the influence of the academic community or international organizations), individual bureaucrats have discretion in whether and how to incorporate impact evidence. This produces existing variation in its use, particularly in countries without strong institutional requirements for evidence-based policy. Recent work shows that bureaucratic evidence-use cultures vary across sectors and among officials (Saguin et al. 2024). Because our sample likely includes officials with both high and low baseline interest in research, and treatment assignment was randomized, our design captures effects that are likely conservative: the presence of less evidence-oriented officials could have attenuated rather than inflated treatment differences.

This paper examines how something that is within the influence of the academic community—the messaging surrounding the use of academic impact evidence—might increase the consultation of such evidence by bureaucrats. Our findings underscore the need to balance scholars' focus on generalizability with policymakers' concern for applicability (Williams 2020), emphasizing the importance of integrating both psychological and institutional approaches in future research. To examine the effects of social and psychological factors in different institutional settings, one possible path is conducting individual-level research on the bureaucracy while selecting specific countries or ministries with the desired institutional variation (Peters 2021).

In particular, the results presented here suggest that the nationality of the messenger influences user demand for academic impact evidence in some contexts. In Peru, bureaucrats expressed greater interest when invitations were issued by U.S. rather than local messengers. In India and Tanzania, the results were mostly insignificant. Our findings speak directly to concerns about the liability of foreignness applied to academic research and government-academia interactions: variation in responses to U.S.-origin versus locally affiliated messengers suggests that trust in external actors is context-dependent. Language issues may have contributed to these differential outcomes, though other reasons are possible. For the number of people trained in meetings, the U.S.-messenger treatment was positively signed for all three countries. We speculate that messenger credibility was important for this result, especially because bureaucrats' motivation to

attend an in-person training hosted by a foreign academic potentially signals trust. This is a useful insight for organizations interested in promoting evidence use in developing countries.

The cross-country variation in response to messenger nationality underscores that evidence uptake is shaped by institutional and political environments rather than by any fixed evaluation of foreign or local expertise. The United States serves here not as a normative benchmark, but as a concrete, globally influential actor whose perceived legitimacy varies across bureaucratic contexts. The differences we observe therefore highlight how trust, professional identity, and geopolitical meaning shape the channels through which evidence travels into policy.

For the social-proof treatment, our findings suggest that bureaucrats do not appreciably increase demand for academic evidence when exposed to social proof referencing the behavior of peers. This finding stands in sharp contrast to prior studies in the psychology of choice considering different populations (Cialdini, Reno, and Kallgren 1990; Nolan et al. 2008; Schultz, Khazian, and Zaleski 2008). They often show that priming peer behavior induces subjects to engage in similar behavior. Furthermore, they reinforce the notion that, unlike suggested by Public Choice scholars (e.g., Tullock, Brady, and Seldon 2002), public employees do not necessarily react to the same incentives of "people in general." This is an instructive and novel finding about how the bureaucratic context changes the interpretations and incentives around messaging that other people are behaving in a particular way. Rather than communicating a norm that should be observed, it seems indicating that others already have knowledge is more likely to reduce the importance or the value of that information. Understanding this difference is important when considering how the academic community can craft messaging about the use of academic evidence by government officials.

As with the messenger treatment, national context matters for peer influence. Social proof had negative effects in India and Tanzania, but no effect in Peru. Again, we can speculate as to why the social-proof intervention caused a negative response, focusing on a combination of the difference in elite behavior, the avoidance of duplication in agencies with scarce resources, and the possibility of rationally deferring to coworkers engaging the issue since the competitive advantage is diluted. These explanations are compatible with the need to optimize resources (including time) in public bureaucracies in the developing world.

Future work should compare how different forms of evidence—such as systematic reviews, curated syntheses, and individual evaluations—interact with bureaucratic evidence cultures to shape uptake. Our design holds evidence format constant in order to isolate messenger and peer effects, but doing so also points toward the value of subsequent studies examining how bureaucrats engage with different types of synthesized knowledge.

Overall, the experiment provides some evidence about how to structure efforts to disseminate academic evidence to developing country bureaucrats. In the absence of explicit, bureaucratic mandates to identify or undertake policy-evaluation studies (which are generally absent in developing countries), academic evidence will only be consulted in the policy-making process based on the interests and efforts of individual bureaucrats. In fact, the literature shows that a substantive number of civil servants do not see academic research as constructive to their work (see Newman, Cherney, and Head 2016). Identifying methods to increase that individual-level demand is thus essential for scholars and analysts who create and disseminate academic evidence about the effectiveness of development programs.

It is worth underscoring that this research represents more than an academic exercise. This study involves a sincere attempt to curate one part of the vast evaluation literature in development policy and programs, and make it accessible through short summaries and consistent, comparable graphical representations. The search for interventions that heighten uptake by some actual bureaucrats is therefore both relevant to academic discussions about bureaucratic responsiveness and also a means of learning how to spread policy-relevant academic evidence most effectively. We used an approach that might be characterized as middle-manager contact. It may be the case that no intervention can be terribly successful in the absence of high-level leadership. In future research, we will examine a more top-down approach in which we attempt different

messaging techniques within an environment where high-level officials have clearly mandated the importance of evidence in policy processes.

This study offers practical guidance for strengthening government-academia linkages and increasing bureaucratic engagement with evaluation evidence. The intervention we test is one that governments and research organizations routinely attempt: inviting bureaucrats to learn about and apply external research findings. Our results highlight that the effectiveness of such efforts depends on the credibility of the messenger and on how bureaucrats interpret peer signals under workload and coordination constraints. These findings suggest that designing evidence-translation strategies requires attention not only to the quality of the research itself, but to the organizational and social contexts within which bureaucrats decide whether engaging with new information is worthwhile. As governments increasingly seek to institutionalize evidence-informed policymaking, understanding these dynamics is essential for building sustainable pathways for research use in everyday administrative practice.

The study contributes to the growing literature on behavioral public administration by demonstrating that bureaucratic evidence uptake is shaped not only by institutional capacity or macro-level incentives, but also by micro-level perceptions of messenger credibility and peer behavior. By using a real-world behavioral measure—bureaucrats' willingness to allocate time to learn and disseminate evidence—we move beyond the survey-based indicators that dominate research on evidence-informed policymaking. The finding that social proof can be counterproductive in bureaucratic settings highlights how highly institutionalized contexts are likely to cause behavioral interventions to have different impacts than in other domains. These results suggest that strategies to promote evidence use must be sensitive to the distinct professional norms, workload constraints, and reputational logics of public bureaucracies.

Notes

1. Throughout this article, we use the terms bureaucrats to refer to unelected public employees who participate in shaping policy through agenda-setting, technical design, and decisions related to implementation.
2. The authors declare no conflicts of interest. The Institutional Review Board at Brigham Young University approved the research on 14 July 2017, approval number E17162. The bureaucrats were provided by email or in person with a statement of implied consent.
3. See, for example, the World Health Organization's Evidence to Policy Summit, August 29-31, 2023, https://www.who.int/initiatives/evidence-informed-policy-network/e2psummit2023.
4. Ministry of Economy and Finances. Peru. "What is evidence?" https://www.mimp.gob.pe/omep/gestion-de-evidencias-mimp.php, accessed 26 Aug. 2024.
5. The website is publicly available at https://impactevidence.org.
6. The Anholt Ipsos Nation Brands Index (https://www.ipsos.com/sites/default/files/19-05-50_Anholt_v2.pdf) and the Brand Finance Nation Brands Report (https://brandirectory.com/rankings/nation-brands/) are prominent examples.
7. In related survey research (Beesley, Hawkins and Moffit 2022), nearly half the bureaucrats rated academic evidence as the most desirable source for policy information among seven sources, including experience and education.
8. See https://www.povertyactionlab.org/evaluations.
9. See https://www.worldbank.org/en/research/dime.
10. Further details are found in the Supplementary Information, Note A1.
11. The exact script is shown in the Supplementary Information.
12. Controlling for the number of contacts produces similar results.
13. In both the pooled and individual country models we include method of contact as a control variable to account for impacts it may have had on responses.
14. Results are similar in models that also include fixed effects for ministry grouping. We show that probit or negative binomial models produce similar results (see Supplementary Information, Tables A13-A36).
15. Supplementary Information, Tables A11-A12 present heterogenous treatment effects by managerial position for Peru and Tanzania.
16. Alternatively, in the Supplementary Information, Tables A37-40, we analyze the later decisions using Heckman-style selection corrections.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This work is supported by College of Family Home and Social Sciences, Brigham Young University.

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